RAJASTHAN

Where Smoke Shows a Mirror

The Pachpadra refinery fire, a day before launch, shines a heated torch on India's lax compliance collapse

By **Rohit Parihar**



PLUMES OF CONCERN Fire breaks out at HPCL Pachpadra Refinery, Balotra, Rajasthan, Apr. 20

IF THE SYMPTOM IS A FIRE, EXPECT the trail to be all smoke, never leading beyond the immediate cause. But check the sheer frequency of large-scale fire accidents of late. In just one mid-April week, India saw five major ones, including two industrial mishaps and two firecracker units in the South going pyrotechnic. But the one at Pachpadra, Rajasthan, got extra focus. It was a day away from going onstream as India's most advanced public sector petrochemical complex. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was to inaugurate it on April 21. Instead, a showpiece moment turned into a reminder of how fragile India's industrial safety culture is.

The scale of ambition makes that starker. The refinery—owned by HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Limited (HRRL), a joint venture between Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited and the state—is to have a full petrochemicals hub around it, within a 100 sq. km radius in the desert district, Balotra, carved out of Barmer in 2023. The incident may slip off the headlines. But policymakers would do well to retain a proactive memory of this latest symptom of India's compliance collapse.

The fire reportedly originated in the crude distillation unit (CDU), likely due to hydrocarbon leakage from a valve or flange in the heat circuit. Officials are dousing the public embarrassment, saying the flames were contained within the heat exchanger stack, with adjacent units isolated in time. No casualties were reported. But the official narrative begins to fray here. Damages could be very high as the affected unit itself cost Rs 6,000 crore. With temperatures dangerously high, even entry for damage assessment was restricted. The impact could take weeks, if not months, to fully map. Some unwelcome symbolism, meanwhile, lay in the fact that the fire broke out at the very site where Modi was scheduled to perform a ceremonial *havan* to mark the refinery's launch.

Takeaways

- **Fire erupts in Rs 80,000 cr Pachpadra petro refinery**
- **On eve of launch by PM; the latest in a series of mishaps**

The NIA will probe the sabotage angle, especially since the SPG had already secured the venue. But the question remains: was the system pushed too far, too fast? The story of delay, followed by urgency, suggests so. Conceived by the UPA in 2013, the project stalled, only to be revived, expanded, then hastened, while costs doubled to nearly Rs 80,000 crore. The inaugural day, Akha Teej, was to be auspicious. A target crowd of 250,000 was met amid wedding season, hundreds of vehicles mobilised, Modi cutouts lined the route. Insiders say the unit may have ended up footing the bill.

Congress leaders Tika Ram Jully and Gehlot demanded a transparent probe, pointedly asking whether the event was expedited ahead of the Bengal and Tamil Nadu assembly polls. But the problem is deeper, and bipartisan. Extend the accident timeline to the past three months, and we get at least 25-40 significant events nationwide; nearly two-thirds involved fires or related blasts. On April 14, a boiler explosion at a Vedanta plant in Chhattisgarh killed 24 workers. The cumulative toll for 2026 is 68 already. One more would be too many. ■